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REFERENCE ARTICLE

Nationalism in African Politics

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Abstract

African nationalism's origins are found in anti-colonial protest and the artificial boundaries of post-colonial states. But it has proven a resilient force in African politics, alongside the colonially engineered states, with few border changes in the post-independence period. Despite the artificiality of the new states and nations, only a few new states emerge, with most political conflict aimed at ensuring inclusion within the state's original boundaries. The experience of decolonization has led nationalist politics to be coalitional in form rather than ideological, bringing together diverse groups. Nation building strategies are deployed after independence to promote unity and development while depoliticizing, homogenizing, and gendering the nationalist legacy. Memorialization and iconography are deployed in this cause, but unevenly. The decades after independence are marked by single party or no-party rule in which the nationalist generations hold on to power. After the end of the cold war, when multiparty elections resumed in many states, and with the aging nationalists increasingly unable to maintain their hold on power, identity-based politics was transformed into an often violent *politics of belonging*, identifying some ethnic and racial groups as more fully national than others. In states that experienced liberation wars, the generation that led the struggle proved particularly resistant to handing over power, basing their claims on their *nationalist* credentials and seeking to discredit others. Yet generational and technological change ensured that subaltern groups, through creative and social media, as well as political movements, continued to claim, contest, and transform national imaginaries.

Keywords: nationalism, decolonization, post-liberation, independence, national identity, memorialization, toponymy, African politics

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Introduction

The political convulsions wracking Cameroon, spirited team support for Nigeria and Senegal at the World Cup, and peace overtures between Ethiopia and Eritrea ending 20 years of war all remind us that nationalism is a living, breathing phenomenon that shapes, and is shaped by, African politics. While it may seem easy to consign nationalism to history and see it as a relic of the colonial period, nationalist politics continue to influence contemporary political engagement in diverse and contradictory ways. Nation building matters not because there is no nationalism, but because there have been and continue to be *competing* nationalisms (Dorman, 2005b; Larmer & Lecocq, 2018).

Postcolonial African leaders have sought to harness the power of nationalism, even as they have been wary of its potential to unleash social forces and destabilize the status quo. It seems hard to believe that, at one time, the very existence of African nationalism was questioned, as observers now acknowledge its power at the heart of political discourses and struggles for control of the state and its resources, even though we often disagree about its significance and attribution.

Political scientists observe the ways and means by which nationalism has been constructed, and the influences this has had on postcolonial politics, as well as the influence that political institutions have had on the evolution of nationalism. They ask: What does it mean to be "Ghanaian" or "Tanzanian"? How are these identities shaped and by whom? To explore the salience of nationalism in contemporary African politics, despite apparently weak state institutions, it is necessary to first unpack what is meant by *nationalism*, and its origins, before exploring how it has interacted with postcolonial state structures.

This process examines the production, reproduction, and contestation of nations. Politics in postcolonial states in Africa retains "winner-takes-all" tendencies, in which even apparently "banal" aspects of nation-building are highly political and contested. Adebanwi (2018, p. 8) inverts Eagleton to suggest that the postcolonial nation is "elusively spectral" and lacking in corporality, but this should not be read as evanescent or likely to vanish. Rather, the nation "contains multitudes," which manifest themselves in conflicting and contested apparitions, but this process of nation making shapes political subjectivities, norms of citizenship, and political institutions. In this way, African nationalism is much like nationalism elsewhere in the world.

Colonialism: A Starting Place?

As a political movement, nationalism in African states combines two agendas: first, the removal of imperial power or settler authority was the primary objective; second, the building of new, self-governing, states (Rathbone, 2000, p. 7). But these are by no means distinct, nor are they the only ways in which nationalism manifests itself. While anti-colonial nationalism emerged at a moment when the world stage was also experiencing pangs of self-determination and was famously shaped by the experiences, scholarship increasingly identified the local experience of imperialism and colonialism as drivers, and these continued to shape the experience of nationalist politics well after independence was achieved. How people experienced the impact of the colonial dispossession of their land and rights depended on their location, gender, status, belief system, and ethnicity. Even within small geographical areas, how an individual or community experienced colonialism differed greatly, and often reactions and engagement with nationalist politics was also diverse.

Nationalist politics, even within individual countries, was thus not a homogenous movement, but a patchwork, linking together diverse and often divergent interests. Colonialism transformed social identities and political structures in hugely diverse ways, leaving contested and overlapping interests, identities. and nationalisms. With the increase of urbanization, labor migration, and the increased communication across states came the advent of mass nationalism. Nationalism was not just a reaction to the injustices of colonialism, but also was a

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result of those social and economic changes. In West Africa, the precursors of nationalist parties formed in the 1880s, while in east and southern Africa, elite associations took shape in the 1920s and 1930s. These early parties, which made fairly limited demands for elite enfranchisement, were transformed in the 1940s and 1950s, as younger, more radical political activists, often influenced by trades union politics and inspired by the independence of Asian colonies, joined them. Within the colonial metropoles, the growing cold war and the lessening economic benefits of colonial ties contributed to decreasing support for holding onto colonies against their will. Anticolonial nationalism was not only influential in the colony, but also in the metropole, as the hegemonic premise weakened and former colonial powers "found it easier to transfer Africa's growing problems to African successors" (Iliffe, 1995, p. 253). In many African countries (but not in the settler states of southern and eastern Africa) "colonizers recognised the inevitable and orchestrated a hand-over to chosen successors" (Ake, 1996, p. 3). In these countries, decolonization was thus less of a radical reconfiguring and more of a "racial integration" of elites, but the nationalist politics that had driven the de-colonization agenda continued to shape political developments in independent states.

Nationalism and Border Politics in New States

Generations of African nationalists have been influenced by pan-Africanist writings and strategies, but in practice, nationalist parties adhered to colonial boundaries for their organizing principles and sought independence through the colonially agreed boundaries. The resilience of nationalism in Africa has gone hand in hand with the resilience of states. Despite their artificiality, there have been few border changes and even fewer conflicts over borders (Clapham, 2010). African conflicts have tended to be struggles for control of the state, not attempts to fragment or create new states.

Where borders have changed in response to demands for national self-determination—Eritrea, Namibia, and South Sudan—the result has been to return borders to pre-WWI colonial boundaries. Of the few attempts to overcome those boundaries, only the union of Tanganyika and Zanzibar to create modern Tanzania has been sustained, but even it might not be judged a "success"(Cameron, 2018). The significance of this is difficult to untangle. The tenacity of these arbitrary lines drawn on a map reveals a sense of attachment to national identities, but also the pragmatic real-politick of Africa's leaders, within the constraints of the global system. The instrumental manipulation of national identity is fueled by desperate strategies for survival on the part of politicians. To some, it is puzzling when they realize that most conflicts in Africa have been conflicts to control the destiny of a country. These *civil* conflicts are best understood as struggles for the soul of the country. There are pragmatic as well as ideological reasons for this. For this reason, nationalism in much of Africa has generally tended to manifest itself in a struggle for control of the state, where political institutions are unable to accommodate pressures for representation. In countries with fragile accords or permanent minorities, groups that have been alienated or excluded may feel forced to fight for inclusion in the state. It is far less common in Africa for nationalism to be expressed as a conflict between two states, or as demands for secession, although it has become slightly more common since the end of the Cold War (de Vries, Englebert, & Schomerus, 2018). Only in one region do we see this pattern, and that is in the Horn of Africa, where nationalism often plays out very differently.

In the Somali-speaking regions, nationalism took the form of irredentism—seeking to unite the Somali linguistic and ethnic groups, which had been divided among five states. Nationalist movements in the Horn were further shaped by their distinct patterns of state formation, in that neither Ethiopia and Sudan were purely colonial creations, but formed around precolonial states that had further taken shape during the colonial period, influenced by external and internal pressures. In the Horn, borders were not drawn randomly on the map by colonial explorers, agglomerating precolonial identities. Instead we see a process of indigenous state formation whereby the Abyssinian Kingdom and the Mahdi's Sudan expanded into new territory and modernized in response to colonial penetration. The persistence of Sudan and Ethiopia, even as Eritrea was

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colonized by the Italians and Somalia divided amongst the French, British, Italians, and Ethiopians, generated a different dynamic to statehood. As Ruth Iyob noted, these states have always faced each other, looking inwards not outwards in their behavior (Iyob, 2000). In Sudan, wracked by civil conflict even before independence, insurgent forces spoke of creating a "New Sudan" and only latterly of "South Sudan." Their goal for many years was to transform the state, not to divide a nation. Likewise, in Somaliland, Hoehne argued that the creation of a new (if as yet unrecognized) state was "an unintended consequence of anti-regime struggle and collapse of the parent-state" (Hoehne, 2018). But that does not mean that Somaliland's sense of nationhood is any less real.

In the Horn, borders are far more salient markers of statehood and nationhood, even though both have been repeatedly challenged internally and externally. Most strikingly, it is only in the Horn that African states have repeatedly gone to war with each other over territorial claims and national pride. Ethiopia and Somalia have twice come into formal conflict, and Eritrea and Ethiopia fought a bitter conflict between 1998 and 2000, only resolved in 2018. It is also a region marked by secession, with the "successful" cases of Eritrea and South Sudan, and the equally successful, but still not internationally recognized case of Somaliland. In these states, nationalism often proves a powerful force—enabling the mobilization of soldiers, money, and moral support.

This doesn't mean that it is any less contested than in other regions—here too we see nationalist movements with complicated histories and valorizing myths that are fought over internally and externally (Dorman, 2005a; Riggan, 2016).

Nationalism as Political Practice

Across the continent nationalist parties contained within themselves a disparate group of interests, bound within the shared borders and linked by their common grievance against colonialism. These included ethnic and religious groups with conflicting experiences of colonialism, professionals with interests in accessing training and elite jobs, workers concerned with working conditions, and peasants whose livelihoods had been disrupted by colonial agrarian projects and constraints. Although self-rule was a shared goal, political parties often competed as much as they cooperated, with often incompatible political agendas (Anderson, 2005), and were driven by local concerns as much as by national ones (Lonsdale, 2013). As a result, factionalism and tensions marked these groups, with frequent divisions and schisms.

For the settler colonies where only an armed struggle brought independence, an additional pressure was brought to bear, with international organizations requiring groups to form united fronts in order to gain recognition. Yet, rather than bringing groups together, competition between disparate groups often became more intense after the main objective—independence—was won. Political strategies and organizations evolved to respond to this challenge—expanding their coalitions. Most nationalist parties were already coalitions, representing different generational and ideological trends, or regional groupings, but most expanded and absorbed rivals, rather than contracting and competing. Kenya's African National Union (KANU) incorporated the Kenya African Democratic Union (KADU); Zambia's United National Independence Party (UNIP) absorbed the African National Congress (ANC); Zimbabwe's African National Union (ZANU) emerged out of, and later reincorporated ZAPU; Mozambique's Frelimo included members of the National Democratic Union of Mozambique, the Mozambique National Union, and the National Union for Mozambican Independence. In South Africa, both the ANC and the National Party (NP) also followed this pattern despite their radically divergent origins—expanding and contracting their membership over decades until eventually the ANC incorporated the NP (Trapido, n.d.). Opponents had to choose between joining the ruling alliance or risking suppression. But in most cases, the opportunity to join was open to all who accepted the terms of inclusion. As Aristide Zolberg, the eminent scholar of francophone West Africa's early nation-building pointed out, Africa's "single parties" were not in fact "parties uniques" but "parties unifies"—unified parties that brought together many disparate tendencies that shape their behavior and trajectories. Anderson put this well when speaking of

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Kenya's parties in the 1950s and 1960s, which he described as "coalitions of varied and diverse local politics, complex organizations within which negotiation and compromise were constant features" (Anderson, 2005, p. 548). The battle to centralize and control political parties required great skill. Houphuet Boigny's Cote d'Ivoire, showed a master politician at work. In 1957, Boigny's PDCI dominated elections, winning 89% of the vote and 58 out of 60 seats. The 1959/1960 constitution provided for opposition parties, but none contested PDCI dominance. Boigny cleverly used the electoral mechanisms to generate coalitions, which disincentivized potential opponents from running against his chosen candidates (Zolberg, 1966, 1969).

Faced with pent-up demands for political and economic change, but limited resources, nationalist leaders became increasingly anxious to solidify control. In most postcolonial states, the only structures able to mobilize similar numbers to the nationalist parties were churches, the military, and trade unions. While in many countries, churches were tainted by their ties to the colonial power and hence reticent in their political engagement, soldiers and workers often felt that their efforts to bring independence justified immediate returns—career advancement, improved wages, and political recognition.

Nationalist politics thus relied upon curbs on trade unions or inclusion in the party to maintain their political hegemony. A wave of strikes involving hundreds of thousands of workers ensured that political leaders acted quickly to ensure trades unions lost their autonomy. In countries like Nigeria, Ghana, and Zambia, trade unions were strengthened by the postcolonial dispensation, but more firmly tied into state control. They became economically and politically dependent on the state, which itself became more unitary and centralized. In Kenya, the two existing labor organizations were dissolved and merged to create the "central organization of trades unions" removing patronage links to Kenyatta's main opponents. The new arrangement benefitted workers economically but ensured that competing power bases were weakened. Likewise, after a wave of mutinies in 1964, political leaders in Kenya, Tanzania, and Uganda acted quickly to bring their militaries more closely under political control. In Tanzania, Nyerere's TANU had been relatively unchallenged by other political parties, but the 1964 army mutiny shook it to its core. Nyerere disbanded the army and rebuilt it with committed nationalist cadres. Nyerere backed up these institutional moves with a range of strategies to enhance national identity and render political mobilization through ethnic groups unfeasible. He did this through a series of cultural interventions: making ethnic identities unfashionable, reducing chiefly power, and promoting Swahili as a national language. These tactical moves reinforced a common narrative and limited the availability of alternative identities around which competing interests might organize.

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Nationalism as Armed Struggle

In the settler colonies, like Rhodesia, Mozambique, Angola, and South Africa, where settlers were unwilling to accept decolonization and universal franchise, nationalists turned to armed struggle to achieve their political goals. Only a handful of African states experienced liberation wars, and even within that select group, most experienced negotiated transitions, rather than violent turnovers, with Zimbabwe's liberation being negotiated in London, and Mozambique and Angola reaping the benefits of Portugal's Carnation Revolution. The cases where independence movements actually seized power physically, "at the barrel of the gun," are remarkably few, but these armed struggles nonetheless shaped political behavior and institutions (Dorman, 2006; Melber, 2002; Southall, 2013). Even more exceptionally, in Eritrea, Namibia, and Western Sahara, three prolonged liberation struggles were waged, not against European powers, but against neighboring states. Here experiences diverged significantly: Namibia's conflict was resolved through negotiations, Eritrea's through the downfall of the Dergue and military capture of Asmara, while Western Sahara remains unliberated. Nationalism manifested itself in particularly distinctive ways in Eritrea with its exceptional path to statehood, but in all of the cases, the nationalist parties that led the armed struggle retained remarkable staying power in post-liberation states. Looking at South Africa in particular, Beresford interrogated how the ANC, much like other nationalist parties in the region, positioned itself as the sole inheritor and protector of the liberation project, but he also identified a regenerative nationalism that goes beyond *legacy*, through which the ANC is able to sustain and reproduce its electoral support when grappling with the challenges of governing the new "rainbow nation" (Beresford, 2016). Similar patterns mark the contemporary politics of all those countries that experienced an armed struggle, with protracted struggles generating particularly intense legacies (Dorman, 2006; Riggan, 2016).

Despite these complex origins and legacies, the narratives of nationalism that emerged during struggles for self-determination and non-racial elections emphasized *unity* and maintained a singular focus on *self-determination*. In part simply modeling themselves on what nationalism was meant to be, it was also a defensive strategy: "if you're not with us, you're against us." This was most common where nationalists were subject to infiltration and destabilization. In settler states like Rhodesia (now Zimbabwe) and Mozambique, settlers sought to frame independence struggles as comprised of *competing* nationalist narratives. So, while white settler narratives of "taming" the land and "civilizing" the people were valorized, black nationalists were depicted as misguided at best, and evil at worst. Attempts to "divide and conquer" by colonial officials made nationalists deeply untrusting of internal splinter groups and pluralism.

These experiences were reinforced as the new governments faced diverse challenges governing fragile new nations. While all of Africa's new nations faced difficult economic and political conditions, some, like Zimbabwe and Mozambique, were actively destabilized by apartheid South Africa, making political elites exceptionally suspicious of those who challenged them politically. Like other leaders before them, the political elites in Zimbabwe, led by Mugabe, were quick to see enemies everywhere and used the demands of *national unity* to imprison and suppress alternative voices. The unity gospel was powerful precisely because unity was so fragile, but seemed so essential, in a political environment where the winner takes all. In this way, the tensions of postcolonial politics ensured that inherited gatekeeper state institutions and first-past-the-post politics intensified, rather than mitigated their centrifugal nature (Allen, 1995). *Unity* became the buzzword of independent states buffeted by the pressures of the Cold War and fluctuating international markets, and served to justify regime excesses. In these newly independent states teachers, churches, trades unionists, musicians, and artists were implored to work together to build unity culturally and politically. The appeal to unity came naturally in states emerging from being under attack from apartheid South Africa, and it was warily welcomed by populations buffeted by the deep factional strife of the liberation struggles. Yet it also set the stage for political projects that framed and perpetuated a narrowly conceptualized project. Nation-building thus linked political strategies and projected norms of citizenship, dominating the available political space, and squeezing

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out competing voices that could lay claim to the nationalist discourse or otherwise appeal to the voting population.

The strategy of political control ensured that each region or ethnic group was given some access to political office and state resources, but preferential access was given to the most politically significant ethnic group or region. Despite competition within the party, real power was held by a small group of politicians, most of whom were also businessmen, who profited economically from their links to the state: combined centralized bureaucratic direction of policy and administration, with regional distribution of patronage. Everyone included in the party/state gets access to patronage, but not equally. Rivalry for seats emphasized local grievances and what a politician might deliver rather than ideological issues—strengthening vertical cleavages rather than the cross-cutting cleavages that might unite groups across ethnic or religious divisions (which often reinforce ethnic boundaries). In this context, identity politics became more, rather than less, intensive (Berman, 1998). For some decades, the creation of single parties stifled these tensions, sweeping them under the carpet, but as the Cold War ended, pressures for democratization bubbled up again. But lacking ideological bases on which to organize, identity politics again took center stage. Belonging to the nation and being able to make a claim on political resources became increasingly significant, especially in the economically challenging years of austerity and liberalization. It is in this context that national and ethnic identities were being deployed instrumentally by political elites to exclude ethnic and racial groups from access to political goods, voting, and political power(Bøås & Dunn, 2013; Dorman, Hammett, & Nugent, 2007). This took the form of mass expulsions, ethnic violence, genocides, and xenophobic violence against migrants.

The Cultural Politics of Nation-Building

Nationalist politics was not simply a negative or instrumental process. The challenges of modern states require positive construction of national identity in the face of competing nationalisms (Dorman, 2005a; Larmer & Lecocq, 2018). It is easy to be dismissive of symbolic overtures toward nation-building, and see them either as politically instrumental moves aimed solely at keeping elites in power, or as inconsequential gestures that fail to satisfy populations lacking material benefits of independence. But jointly with institutional practices and material politics, “cultural politics” shape political subjectivities, producing citizens and patriots of their states, or indeed, generations that reject those labels. For young states, the projection of statehood is intertwined with the projection of nationhood and the creation of particular forms of citizenship. Political scientists need to take them seriously to understand practices and norms that shape political behavior.

As Larmer and Lecoq argued, we should not mistake or conflate weak state institutions for a failure or absence of nationalism (Larmer & Lecocq, 2018). At the same time, it is undeniable that African states contain within them multiple overlapping sets of identities and claims upon people. In this, they are not so different from the multi-ethnic creations of western Europe—which, despite containing great diversity, were formed into modern states in the 19th century, even as the American settler states took shape (Dorman, 2015)—and the later transformation in central and eastern Europe. In Africa, as elsewhere, nation-building was undertaken as a way of resolving internal differences resulting from colonialism’s arbitrary borders and the deep divisions created by colonial “divide and rule” strategies.

For some nationalist movements, this process began well-before independence. Many groups had imagery and modes of dress that signaled their allegiance and used radio stations and visual images to project political messages about who they were to local populations and the outside world (Gidron, 2018; Miescher, Rizzo, & Silvester, 2009; Thompson, 2013). Insurgent groups often went further than this within liberated territories. Need meant that much effort focused on basic service provision (Mampilly, 2011), which in cases like Eritrea, included schools, hospitals, veterinary services, markets, and taxation (Pool, 2001). Eritrea’s People’s Liberation Front (EPLF) issued identity cards and postage stamps, as well as directing a cultural troupe (Matzke, 2003).

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The unsuccessful nationalists of Biafra also created a flag and an anthem, and issued postage stamps—now collectors' items (Omogbenigun, 2018).

Upon independence, the first and foremost task for many nationalist movements was the need to confirm the new nation's name and, where appropriate, rename streets and cities. In Eritrea's capital Asmara, the streets the EPLF had marched down when the Dergue fell were rapidly renamed—choosing mainly abstract signifiers or commemorating battles. Godena Harnet (Liberation Avenue) replaced the Dergue's National Avenue, which had itself replaced Avenue Haile Selassie, and still earlier Viale Benito Mussolini. Mozambique denoted key dates in the history of the liberation struggle in place names, but most distinctively honored numerous Communist leaders: Marx, Engels, Lenin, Kim il Sung, and Mao (Cruz, 2017). Many new states honored pan-Africanist and nationalist leaders from across the continent: Nyerere, Nkrumah, Lumumba, Machel, and Kaunda are all commemorated in numerous capitals. Tanzania's first wave of street renaming similarly commemorated foreign political leaders, as well as local political figures. Notably, the renaming of Victoria Street to Bibi Titi Mohamed, a female leader of TANU, was revoked while she was on trial for treason, but later reinstated. Many other capitals similarly have one or at most two streets named for nationalist women or precolonial figureheads, although South Africa's renamings have tended to be more diverse than elsewhere (Adebanwi, 2018). In Zimbabwe, most streets named after colonial settlers were renamed in honor of deceased heroes of the liberation war, but from among those still living only Robert Mugabe was so honored. Thirteen government buildings were renamed in 1985, but many schools retained their colonial-era names until a second wave of renaming began in 2002, and military barracks were only renamed in 2017. In many cases, the first wave of renamings are more notable for those left out for political reasons, some of whom are eventually recognized by later generations of politicians (for an exploration of this in Kenya, see Wanjiru & Matsubara, 2017).

Memorialization in the landscape followed toponymy, but this likewise risked opening up debates. In Zimbabwe and Namibia, memorialization of the war dead was a top-down, hierarchical process, controlled and designed to make the liberation struggle an exclusive performance, not a participatory one (Becker, 2011; Kossler, 2003; Kriger, 1995; Werbner, 1998). In Eritrea, by contrast, monuments and cemeteries are non-hierarchical, egalitarian, and moving—the giant sandal in the traffic circle in central Asmara commemorates the simple footgear of the soldiers in the struggle. And the cemeteries that commemorate martyrs are modest as well—no one fighter is singled out for greatness. (Dorman, 2005a, 2005b, 2008).

In both Namibia and Zimbabwe, post-liberation governments chose a policy of "studied silence" rather than risk stirring up past conflicts (Kossler, 2003). Commemorative strategies were thus limited in scope, and received low political priority, perhaps because they risked opening tensions resulting from divisions and silences within nationalist movement. Only when the nationalist generation had either died or was handing over power were moves made to commemorate particular heroes. At independence, Kenya faced divisions between radical nationalists who had fought in Mau Mau and the more conservative politicians who took power after independence. This was resolved by taking the issue firmly off the table, although popular historical accounts of Mau Mau flourished (Parsons, 2018). Only in 2003 did President Mwai Kibaki revoke the official ban on Mau Mau membership, and it took until 2006 for a statue of Dedan Kimathi to be erected (Branch, 2010; Coombes, 2011). It is thus unsurprising that in Zimbabwe, little memorialization of the independence struggle took place beyond the establishment of Heroes' Acre and discussion of such issues was taken firmly off the table (Fontein, 2006; Lee, 1995; Mataga, 2014). It was only in 2002 that a statue was commissioned to commemorate the iconic Joshua Nkomo, leader of ZANU's predecessor and competitor party, ZAPU, and even then, many interpreted it as an attempt by ZANU to claim Nkomo's legacy. Grandiose memorials risk generating controversy and sparking their own counter-narratives, as Senegal's President Wade discovered when he sought to mark 50 years of independence through a dramatic statue constructed by a North Korean workforce at a cost of £27 million.

But nation-building was not just about nationalist or liberation iconography. Leaders also looked further back to a heroic precolonial past, or envisioned the state moving toward the future, to create a more harmonious

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present. Common and dominant themes in many states were *development* and *modernization*—emphasizing a depoliticized forward progression. In Rwanda, Purdekova (2015) noted, "development has an uncanny gravity, pulling everything into its orbit." Referring to development as an "elusive and ambiguous beacon" she posits that unity and societal reconciliation are byproducts of development. This framing will be familiar also to those who studied the early post-independence years of Zimbabwe and many other nations. Cusack suggests that strategies of nation-building and national integration initially were explicitly designed around "the promotion of modern industrial technologies," but economic weakness, followed by neoliberal trade regimes limited these options, and the "ruling elites had to look to the past and to tradition in order to construct a shared national culture . . . fostering discourses of shared cultural roots, however real or fictive these were or are" (Cusack, 2003, p. 278). Purdekova focused on Rwanda's re-education camps, but similar motifs appear across the state. An examination of stamps issued in Zimbabwe post-1980 shows the imagery and iconography as predominantly of science and technology, or carefully apolitical natural and cultural heritage; rarely does it look backward at the heroes of the liberation struggle. This cleverly avoided too many questions that risked opening up divisions and rifts among elites about their personal involvement. This is again nicely contrasted by Eritrea, where stamps often espouse explicitly nationalist motifs—"one nation; one heart"—but also depicted liberation war iconography and, after the 1998–2000 conflict with Ethiopia, portrayed young dying soldiers. Yet, as ZANU's influence waned after decades in power, Mugabe turned toward what Terence Ranger called *patriotic history*, indoctrinating youth with a particular historical narrative, rewriting textbooks, and excavating (literally) the material remains of the liberation war. Attention then turned to schools, army barracks, and other institutions that had retained the names of British monarchs decades after independence, and despite Zimbabwe having been thrown out of the Commonwealth.

Depoliticization was also sought control of music and sport through the state. Politicians turned to sport, especially football, as a nation-building strategy. Chipande explored how Kenneth Kaunda's support for Zambian football promoted nationalism, but was also tightly tied to his personal political ambitions (Chipande, 2018; see also Merrett, 2003). Anthems and other political branding are often referred to as "banal nationalism" (Billig, 1995), but they too provide a foundation for molding ideas about African statehood (Cusack, 2005). Musicians, dancers, and theatre troupes were provided with state support in Tanzania and Ghana, but given a narrow remit to "perform the nation," drawing primarily on traditional cultural modes deployed to convey unity (Askew, 2002; Schauert, 2015). Nowhere has the state's role in rewriting of the nation been so observable as in Rwanda post-1994. Reconstructing the state post-genocide incorporated every possible aspect of the nation-builders' playbook, with attention paid—and real investment in—public memorialization. Performances are likewise designed to depict not just what the nation is, but to involve citizens in performing for the nation on a daily basis (Breed, 2014; Purdeková, 2015; Turner, 2014). These constructions also produce and reproduce gendered notions of citizenship and identity (Cusack, 2000, 2003, 2005).

Political leadership in Kenya, Ghana, Gambia, Botswana, Tanzania, and Zambia turned to national service as a means of integrating different cultures and rebuilding society around a common nationalist ideology ((Patel & Wilson, 2004, p. 29S). In Eritrea, the fighters who had spent 25 years in the bush feared that succeeding generations might lack their own commitment and sacrifice, and sought to instill those values in the youth via an increasingly harsh mandatory national service (Dorman, 2005a; Kibreab, 2017). In Nigeria, Mali, Liberia, and Rwanda, national service was introduced after a period of political crisis or conflict. Nigeria's case is probably the longest lasting and most studied. In an early study of the controversies surrounding the program, Marenin suggested that it has come to be seen "as a ready if temporary source of educated manpower, rather than a year of service and learning to be a Nigerian" (Marenin, 1979, p. 634). Obadare's recent, detailed study further confirmed this analysis, suggesting that while National Service increased youth interaction across social cleavages, it had not succeeded in fostering stronger national ties or national integration (Obadare, 2010, pp. 59–62).

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It would be wrong to see these processes as artificial or meaningless. Although national identity jostles with ethnic, religious, and diasporic identities, and citizens selectively choose those aspects that they find meaningful, nation-building does seem to have laid roots, and inspired new growth. Levels of national attachment vary greatly across the continent, Afrobarometer data suggests that significant proportions of African citizens do feel an attachment to their national identity over, or in addition to, their ethnic or other identities (Miguel, 2004; Robinson, 2009). Intriguingly, a strong correlation exists between modernization and national identity, with more economically developed countries showing higher rates of nationalism. Yet, Tanzania, with relatively low development but which experienced perhaps the most coherent nation-building program, consistently ranks far above its neighbors on such indices, suggesting that Nyerere's strategy worked. Even as citizens pick and choose how to self-identify, often disdaining the overtly political, they nonetheless absorb elements of the nation-building project.

Resurgent Nationalisms: New Coalitions, Diasporas, and Counter-Hegemonic Struggles

Nation-building and debates about national identity also recur in countries that experience political and economic crises, but these are not always led by the nationalist generation. In Zimbabwe, the decision to introduce a new national anthem in 1994, followed by the introduction of national service in 2000 (Mhike, 2018; Shumba, 2006), revealed the increasingly desperate strategies of an aging regime to hold onto power and remobilize the nationalist coalition (Dorman, 2016). In other cases, renewed contestation may reflect the presence of new political elites, seeking to write their own contributions and histories into the cultural backdrop, by introducing a new national flag as President Mutharika controversially did in Malawi in 2010, or by attempts to build new political coalitions and dispel ethnic animosity, as in Kenya before and, especially, after the 2007 elections (Branch, 2010; Scharrer, 2018).

But attempts to redefine the nation also come from the bottom-up, as artists, actors, musicians, journalists and writers use their artistic mediums to challenge and reconfigure ideas about the nation. The rise of social media further enables the articulation of new ideas about the nation and inclusion within it, as Zimbabwe's #ThisFlag movement showed (Gukurume, 2017; Oberdorf, 2017). In Senegal, the Y'en a Marre (enough is enough) movement, and other socially engaged artists, likewise used traditional and new media to articulate ideas of a "new type of Senegal" inclusive of youth and other marginalized groups (Basséne, 2013; Enz & Bryson, 2014; Fredericks, 2014). And in the aftermath of Kenya's 2007–2008 political violence, Scharrer argued that "the idea of Kenya as a nation of diversity was . . . fostered in popular culture" (Scharrer, 2018). Larmer and Lecoq articulated this well, "where nation-states failed to fulfil . . . aspirations, alternative national imaginaries often provided vehicles for expressing criticism of and disillusionment with incumbent rulers" (Larmer & Lecocq, 2018).

Even more strikingly, in South Africa, statues of Cecil Rhodes became the target of protest and vilification in early 2015. Students at the University of Cape Town seized on the statue as a symbol of the failure of the institution—and indeed the nation—to fully transform itself decades after the end of apartheid. These students—and their supporters in the faculty and beyond—were demanding that their institutions and the public face of the state resemble the nation. In linking the statue to the challenges students faced, and to the broader societal inequalities, they too were making claims about the nation they inhabit (Holmes & Loehwing, 2016). Likewise in Burkina Faso, long-standing demands exist for a proper memorial at the grave of Thomas Sankara, which is in poor condition and difficult to access, while Sankara is also held to have inspired recent political mobilizations (Harsch, 2013; Zeilig, 2017)

Diasporas also increasingly engage with and contribute to nationalist projects—some explicitly distancing themselves from politics; some uncritically supporting a regime that they do not have to live under, while

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others provide particularly shrill criticism—but all providing important resources through remittances, skills, and networks. The growth of social media and cell phones, as well as the importance of contributions to home economies, means that diasporic residents feel a stronger connection to their homes and have a greater sense of engagement (Bernal, 2004, 2005; Sorenson & Matsuoka, 2001). Diasporas may be instrumentally incorporated or may actively seek incorporation in the nation. In Ghana, the establishment of *development chiefs* binds those of African descent into community development projects (Bob-Milliar, 2009; Kleist, 2011). Diasporic engagement with development is often explicitly non-political, but these practices tie into patterns of projecting statehood and nationhood beyond the state's borders, as well as internal nation-building strategies (Abebe, 2016; Delpino, 2011; Kleist, 2013). This has also been recognized in a small but significant shift among African nations toward allowing dual nationality (Manby, 2015), and in Kenya and Mali, even to allow citizens abroad to vote, transforming citizenship in minute but meaningful ways. As Kleist argues:

> The diaspora policies and events thus have value as state spectacles. They enable the state to perform and signal political power. . . . State mobilisation of diaspora groups thus not only co-constitutes diasporas as development agents and as subjects for (potential) governance, they also construct the position of a pro-active and inclusive state.
>
> (Kleist, 2013, p. 302)

These outside and bottom-up movements suggest that many aspire to contribute to the shaping of their nations and to articulate ideas about what being a national means or ought to mean. While nationalism often seems orchestrated or driven by political elites, these cases remind us that nationalism in Africa is not a prerogative of politicians. Rather it is a complex and multi-vocal force that has been deeply shaped by international and domestic expectations, but that continues to articulate demands and visions for the future.

Conclusion

Even as some scholars doubted the reality of African nationalism when it first emerged, others questioned its staying power and significance post-independence. Political scientists turned to the study of institutions, leaving nationalism to historians, musicologists, and anthropologists. But nationalism has persisted, alongside other aspects of African politics, to shape our understanding of phenomena. It is easy to see nationalism used instrumentally by political elites to further their own rule. This sort of exclusionary nationalism has led to pogroms, mass deportations, and the removal of vulnerable citizens to the margins of the state. But the ability to mobilize those exclusionary powers builds on the deployment of a more banal nationalism that provides the foundation for norms of nationhood and citizenship.

Nationalism brought particular kinds of politics to the fore—forcing political interests to form coalitions of interest across ethnic and other divides. It also foregrounded discourses of development and unity. These two pressures have reinforced each other and tended to militate against the emergence of ideological politics—generating pressures toward coalitions, governments of national unity, and recycling of elites between and through parties. But the emergent politics also intensified the focus on identity and belonging, which was often deployed instrumentally by political elites. Nevertheless, it would be wrong to understand nationalism as solely a politically instrumental strategy, deployed by political elites in the search for material goods. It is also a political arena where struggles are played out—between elites seeking to create a state in their own image and those seeking to challenge, reclaim, and transform national identity.

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